

Northwind Technologies

Employee Handbook

Version 3.0 | Effective 1 January 2026 | Sample document for demonstration purposes

1. Welcome and Purpose

Welcome to Northwind Technologies. This handbook explains the policies, benefits and expectations that apply to all full-time and part-time employees. It does not create a contract of employment. Where this handbook and local law differ, local law prevails. Questions about any policy can be sent to the People Team at people@northwind.example.

Northwind was founded in 2015 and builds logistics software for mid-sized retailers. Our values are Customer First, Own It, Be Honest and Keep Learning.

2. Employment Basics

2.1 Employment Categories

Full-time employees work at least 36 hours per week. Part-time employees work fewer than 36 hours per week and receive leave and benefits on a pro-rata basis. Contractors are not covered by this handbook.

2.2 Probation Period

All new employees serve a probation period of 90 days. Probation may be extended once by up to 30 days. During probation, either party may end employment with 7 days written notice.

2.3 Working Hours

Standard working hours are 9:30 AM to 6:00 PM, Monday to Friday, including a 45-minute unpaid lunch break. Core collaboration hours are 11:00 AM to 4:00 PM, when employees are expected to be available for meetings.

3. Leave Policy

Leave Type	Entitlement	Notes
Annual Leave	24 days per year	Accrues monthly at 2 days per month. Up to 10 unused days may be carried over to the next year.
Sick Leave	10 days per year	A medical certificate is required for absences longer than 2 consecutive days.
Casual Leave	6 days per year	Cannot be combined with annual leave for more than 5 consecutive days.

Maternity Leave	26 weeks paid	Available after 6 months of service. Notify the People Team at least 8 weeks before the expected date.
Paternity Leave	4 weeks paid	Must be taken within 6 months of the child's birth or adoption.
Bereavement Leave	5 days per event	For immediate family members. 2 days for extended family.
Public Holidays	12 days per year	The holiday calendar is published each December.

3.1 Requesting Leave

Leave requests must be submitted in the HR portal and approved by your manager. Annual leave of more than 3 days should be requested at least 2 weeks in advance. Unplanned sick leave must be reported to your manager before 10:00 AM on the day of absence.

3.2 Unpaid Leave

Unpaid leave of up to 30 days may be granted at the manager's and People Team's discretion after 1 year of service.

4. Remote and Hybrid Work

Northwind follows a hybrid model. Employees are expected to work from the office at least 3 days per week (Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday are the default anchor days). Employees may work remotely on the remaining days without special approval.

Working remotely from a different city or country for more than 10 working days in a year requires written approval from your manager and the People Team, because of tax and legal implications. Employees receive a one-time home office stipend of \$300 to buy a chair, monitor or similar equipment.

5. Compensation and Benefits

5.1 Payroll

Salaries are paid on the last working day of each month by bank transfer. Payslips are available in the HR portal.

5.2 Bonus

Eligible employees receive an annual performance bonus, paid in March, based on company and individual performance. Employees who joined after 1 October of the previous year are not eligible for that year's bonus.

5.3 Health Insurance

Northwind provides group health insurance covering the employee, spouse and up to 2 children, with a family cover of \$15,000 per year. Coverage starts on the first day of employment. Parents can be added at the employee's cost.

5.4 Learning Budget

Each employee has an annual learning budget of \$800 for courses, books and conferences. Requests above this amount need VP approval. If you leave within 12 months of a course reimbursement above \$500, the amount must be repaid.

5.5 Retirement Contribution

Northwind matches employee retirement contributions up to 5% of base salary. Matching contributions vest after 2 years of service.

6. Expenses and Travel

Business expenses must be submitted within 30 days of being incurred, with receipts, through the expense tool. Reimbursement is made in the next payroll cycle.

Expense	Limit
Domestic flights	Economy class only
Hotel	Up to \$180 per night (up to \$250 in high-cost cities)
Meals while travelling	Up to \$60 per day
Client entertainment	Up to \$100 per person, with manager pre-approval
Ground transport	Ride-hailing or public transit; car rental needs manager approval

Alcohol is not reimbursable. Any single expense above \$500 requires prior written approval from your manager.

7. Code of Conduct

Employees are expected to treat colleagues, customers and partners with respect. Harassment, discrimination and bullying of any kind are strictly prohibited. Concerns can be raised with your manager, the People Team, or anonymously through the Ethics Hotline at ethics@northwind.example. Northwind prohibits retaliation against anyone who raises a concern in good faith.

7.1 Conflict of Interest

Employees must disclose any outside business activity or financial interest that may conflict with Northwind's interests. Gifts from vendors or clients worth more than \$50 must be declined or reported to the People Team.

7.2 Dress Code

Dress is business casual. Company-branded clothing is encouraged on Fridays. Client-facing meetings may require smart attire.

8. Information Security and IT Use

Company laptops must use full-disk encryption and automatic screen lock after 5 minutes of inactivity. Passwords must be at least 14 characters and multi-factor authentication is mandatory for all company systems. Report lost devices or suspected phishing to security@northwind.example within 1 hour of noticing.

Customer data must not be stored on personal devices or personal cloud accounts. Employees may not install unapproved software on company laptops. Use of public AI tools with confidential or customer data is not permitted.

9. Performance and Growth

Performance reviews take place twice a year, in June and December. Each review includes a self-assessment, manager feedback and peer feedback. Ratings are on a 1 to 5 scale. Salary revisions are considered in the December cycle, effective 1 January. Employees rated 2 or below are placed on a 60-day performance improvement plan with clear goals and weekly check-ins.

Employees are eligible to apply for internal transfers after 12 months in their current role.

10. Resignation and Exit

The standard notice period is 60 days for employees and 90 days for managers and above. Notice must be given in writing. Unused annual leave up to 15 days is paid out at final settlement; casual and sick leave are not encashable. The final settlement is paid within 30 days of the last working day. All company equipment must be returned on or before the last working day.

An exit interview is conducted by the People Team in the final week of employment.

11. Contacts

Topic	Contact
Leave, payroll, benefits	people@northwind.example
IT support	helpdesk@northwind.example
Security incidents	security@northwind.example
Ethics and conduct concerns	ethics@northwind.example